FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Hindi films often ask their audiences to leave their brains behind at home. And they didn't mind it. But imagine a Bollywood film where a character comes on screen without a head on the shoulders and proceeds to hide the severed head under the bed. Next, imagine such a film becoming the highest-grossing Hindi film ever on home turf, one of the most commercially successful outings in the history of Indian cinema. In short, it's a monster hit—literally. Not even in the wildest scripts could one have foreseen such a twist to our pop culture. But the audiences are lapping up precisely such a film, alternating between shrieks of terror and hopeless laughter. We are talking about *Stree 2: Sarkate ka Aatank (Woman 2: Terror of the Headless)*, the horcom directed by Amar Kaushik. Nor is it an outlier in terms of genre. *Munjya*, a low-budget film from the same consortium, had become a sleeper hit after its release in June. In November comes *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 3*, the next edition of a popular franchise that pretty much inaugurated this style of film. Suddenly, 2024 seems to be the Year of the Horcom. Romcoms seem passé for the moment. The honour of the snazzy abbreviation now goes to a genre that provokes screams from the unlikely blend of fear and mirth.

The numbers tell the story best against a blockbuster from the action genre. Last year, the SRK extravaganza *Jawan* (Hindi) took home Rs 554 crore in domestic collections, becoming the biggest Bollywood hit of all time. *Stree 2* threatens to overtake that, having already grossed Rs 530 crore at the box office in less than a month. It has not come out of the blue: the mood for side-splitting horror has been building up for a while. As the name suggests, *Stree 2* is a sequel, picking up the story of a group of friends battling corny supernatural evil in small-town India from where the first edition of the franchise, *Stree* (2018), left off. It has the same ensemble cast of Rajkummar Rao, Shraddha Kapoor, Pankaj Tripathi et al. That this merry band merited an encore is a sign of how viable the kernel idea is—far-fetched though it may initially seem.

Director Kaushik has emerged as quite the central figure in this emerging trend. Between the two *Stree* films, he had also directed the popular 2022 horcom *Bhediya* (Wolf)—the lifelike figure of its beastly 'protagonist' adorns his Santa Cruz office. Examine the credits of all these films, and you will see the same behind-the-scenes cast. They are all produced, often along with Kaushik, by Dinesh Vijan of Maddock Films—which is slowly becoming the Marvel of Indian horcoms. *Stree 2*, in fact, is the fifth film from the stable if you also count their 2021 outing, *Roohi*. They're calling it the Maddock Horror Comedy Universe. Another man key to its creation is Niren Bhatt, a civil engineer-turned-IT consultant who has now taken to revelling in the unreal evocations of horcom. He has dished out most of these films' story, dialogue and screenplay, interspersing panic moments with what he calls "banana peel" humour, wordplay, slapstick and silly pop culture nods. "Horcom is a medium for spontaneous reaction from audiences," says Bhatt. "It is a community experience. You watch it with others to get the full joy out of it." The perfect recipe, then, to ensure crowds at theatres.



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The films have another common strand. Their stories are drawn from Indian folklore and myth. *Stree* borrowed a '90s urban legend from around Bengaluru, *Munjya* brought to life a Maharashtrian boy spirit that dwells in peepal trees using CGI, *Bhediya* took inspiration from a werewolf tale from Arunachal (where Kaushik spent his early years). Into this, Bhatt works in some social messaging "through visual metaphors and satire". In *Bhediya*, for instance, the wolf is a vehicle to touch on the conflict between natives and outsiders and depleting forests courtesy of rapid industrialisation. "You have to show the audience the mirror, but the messages are to be told not by berating or screaming at them," says Kaushik. Instead, softening them up with gut-busting primal emotions, along with oodles of fun, is the Maddock way.

This week, even as *Stree 2* shrieks past box-office records, Deputy Editor Suhani Singh gives us a break from the horrors and comedies of real life with a cover-length look at the new genre of horcoms. Unlike in the West, horror films have never been much part of the Bollywood mainstream. Its big hits have mostly revolved around the old formula of musicals, revenge sagas, family dramas and, of course, romance, be it tragic or comic. Some lovely ladies clad in white saris walking into the mist provided the only proximity to fear. There is no Hindi film counterpart of *The Exorcist* or even *Jaws*. Ram Gopal Varma's initially promising turn to horror apart, the sole exceptions were the zombie fare offered by the Ramsay Brothers, whose B-level horror flicks could, of course, be unintentionally funny. This time, it's for real. With production values backed by a world-class VFX studio, horror is laughing its way to the bank.

Go check out this new genre, but don't choke on the popcorn!

(Aroon Purie)